

Getting Screened for
Colorectal Cancer



Every cancer. Every life.®

Colorectal cancer is one of the most common cancers, and a top cause of cancer deaths.

If you're age 45 or older and at average risk, you should start getting screened for colorectal cancer.

There's more than one screening test for colorectal cancer. No matter which one you choose, the most important thing is to **get screened**.

What is colorectal cancer?

Cancer that starts in the colon or rectum is often called colorectal cancer. It might also be called colon cancer or rectal cancer. It starts when cells in the colon or rectum grow out of control and crowd out normal cells.

Most colorectal cancers start as abnormal growths called **polyps**. These growths can happen anywhere in the colon and rectum.

Why is colorectal cancer screening important?

Screening can help find colorectal cancer early, when treatment is more likely to be successful.

Regular screening can help prevent colorectal cancer. A polyp can take as many as 10 to 15 years to develop into cancer. Screening helps doctors find and remove polyps before they can turn into cancer.

Colorectal cancer risk factors

If you're age 45 or older and at **average risk**, you should start regular screening tests for colorectal cancer. Average risk means that you don't have certain **risk factors**. Risk factors are things that can increase your chances of getting colorectal cancer.

You might be at an increased risk if you have:

- A personal or family history of colorectal cancer or certain types of polyps
- A personal history of inflammatory bowel disease like ulcerative colitis or Crohn's disease
- A family history of certain cancer syndromes, like familial adenomatous polyposis (FAP) or Lynch syndrome (also known as hereditary non-polyposis colon cancer)
- A personal history of getting radiation to the abdomen (belly) or pelvic area for any cancer

People who are at a **high risk** of getting colorectal cancer may need to start getting screened at a younger age or may need to get screened more often. Talk with your doctor about when you should start regular colorectal screening.

American Cancer Society guideline for colorectal cancer screening

The American Cancer Society (ACS) recommends that people at **average risk** of colorectal cancer **start regular screening at age 45**.

People who are in good health and with a life expectancy of more than 10 years should continue regular screening **through age 75**.

For people ages 76 through 85, the decision to be screened should be based on a person's preferences, life expectancy, health status, and past screening history .

People over age 85 should no longer get colorectal cancer screening.

Screening tests for colorectal cancer included in ACS guideline

Screening tests for colorectal cancer can be done with different types of tests.

Stool-based tests (preferred)

Stool tests check your poop for signs of colorectal cancer. Options include:

- Fecal immunochemical test (FIT)* every year, **or**
- Guaiac-based fecal occult blood test (gFOBT)* every year, **or**

- Multi-targeted stool DNA (mt-sDNA)* test every 3 years, **or**
- Multi-targeted stool RNA (mt-sRNA)* test every 3 years

You collect the sample on your own at home using a test kit and mail or return the kit as instructed. But even though these tests can find signs of some cancers, they can also miss some.

If any of these tests are abnormal, you'll need to get a colonoscopy as a follow-up to complete your screening.

Visual exams of the colon and rectum (preferred)

A doctor uses an instrument to look inside your colon and rectum for polyps and signs of cancer. Options include:

- Colonoscopy every 10 years, **or**
- CT colonography (virtual colonoscopy)* every 5 years, **or**
- Sigmoidoscopy* every 5 years

Each of these exams is different. For a **colonoscopy** and **sigmoidoscopy**, a doctor uses a thin tube with a light and camera to look inside your rectum and colon. If they find any polyps, they will remove them. Or they may take a piece to be tested for cancer (also called a **biopsy**).

Before a colonoscopy or sigmoidoscopy, you'll get directions on how to do a **bowel prep**. A bowel prep cleans out the colon, so the doctor can see it clearly during the exam. The prep might include medicines or liquids you drink that make you poop a lot.

A colonoscopy and sigmoidoscopy are prepped in the same way. But a sigmoidoscopy only looks at the rectum and about half of the colon. A colonoscopy looks at the rectum and entire colon.

A **CT colonography** is different from a colonoscopy and sigmoidoscopy. Air is pumped into your colon. Then a type of x-ray called a CT scan is done to take pictures.

This exam is sometimes called a **virtual colonoscopy** because nothing is placed into your colon. But you will still need to do a bowel prep, so the doctor can get good pictures of your colon. And if the doctor finds a polyp or growth, you will need a colonoscopy to remove it or have a piece taken for testing.

Blood-based tests (not preferred)

Blood-based tests* check for signs of colorectal cancer in a sample of a person's blood. While these tests are an option, they're not preferred at this time. They should only be used if you're not willing to get a stool-based test or visual screening exam.

**If a person gets screened with a test other than colonoscopy, any abnormal test result should be followed up with colonoscopy.*

Which screening test is best for me?

There are some differences between these tests to consider. But the most important thing is to get screened, no matter which test you choose.

Talk with your doctor about which tests might be good options for you. Talk to your insurance provider about which screening tests they cover.

Research shows that nearly half of all cancers can be linked to risk factors you can change.

Take the **ACS CancerRisk360™** assessment to learn more about what you can change to help improve your health and lower your cancer risk.





This booklet is about getting screened for colorectal cancer.

It tells you things like:

- Why screening is important
- Who should get screened and when
- What the different screening tests are

There are many different tests that can be used to check for colorectal cancer in people who don't have symptoms.

The most important thing is to get screened, no matter which test you choose.



For more information and support, visit the American Cancer Society website at **cancer.org/colon** or call us at **1-800-227-2345**. We're here when you need us



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